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NEITHER LAW NOR JUSTICE

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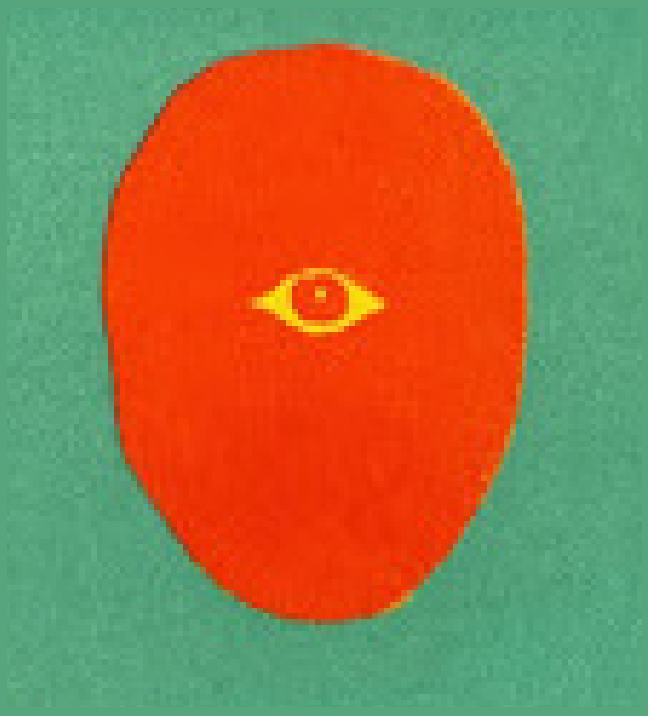
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back in print



an analog artform captivates a new generation of artists

BY **SAENAH BOCH**

IN THE LATE '90S, Alex Valentine, a recent high school graduate, discovered an emerging underground punk scene in the post-industrial warehouses of Providence, Rhode Island. He met artists barely older than himself living in a "lineage of punk houses," dedicating their time to exploring the intersection of art, music, and street fashion.

Among this crowd, "screen printing was this big thing," Valentine recalled. Bands made their own merch with barely legible screen-printed posters. Concertgoers altered thrifted clothes, adding patchwork, quilt work, and hand-printed designs.

Until this encounter, Valentine hadn't envisioned himself as a visual artist. But soon after, he moved to Philadelphia and set up his own silkscreen printing studio, where he started to take printmaking seriously. Two years later he enrolled at the School of the Art Institute of Chicago, which had a dedicated print media program. Valentine dove into the world of self-publishing and bookbinding, creating zines and small-press publications. His investment in print culture and artist-run initiatives stems from his philosophy of print media as a way to "bypass cultural gatekeepers." A self-publishing printmaker can disseminate their own art through channels that are "more democratized," reaching people outside a mainstream audience. With some artist friends, Valentine launched a circuit of art book fairs and opened a collective studio. The studio, a "half-community print shop and half-retail environment," created and sold handmade prints and clothing.

In communal print studios and DIY artist spaces, printmaking can take on many different forms. A multi-step, multi-layered process, printmaking involves the transfer of a design from one surface—such as wood or metal—to another surface, usually paper. But each mark-making technique, whether intaglio, lithography, or screen printing, comes with its own steps and tools.

Alex Valentine is now the Printshop Coordinator at the Yale School of Art, where he teaches classes on screen printing and arts publishing, leads public workshops, and runs the printshop—an open-air studio space in the basement of the MFA building. Everything in the printshop is exposed, from the gray industrial beams to the artists' workstations. The space can feel intimidating. There are signs about the hazards of printmaking, a reminder to avoid accidents like getting acid in your eyes, dropping a lithography stone on your foot, or slicing a finger with the heavy-duty, sheet metal cutter (aptly named the guillotine). It's also a space where you need to get your hands dirty, and it's okay to make a mess. Inside the acid room, an Intro Printmaking student slips on a face shield and a double layer of gloves before she dips her copper plate into the sludge-green acid bath. Her professor, Maria de Los Angeles, helps another student with their print by cranking the wheel of the press.

Printmaking is not an easy form of artmaking. It requires trial and error. It's time-consuming. Even when you do all the right things, there is no guarantee that your print will come out the way you expected. For printmakers, the process is the main reason they fell in love with this medium. It's the feeling of working with your hands—handling the physical materials of paper, carving into a woodblock, straining ink through mesh. Despite its analog nature, printmaking continues to attract new generations of artists, along with non-visual artists and performers like musicians and skaters.

The art form itself is democratic. Jonathan Herrera Soto, a second-year MFA student at the Yale School of Art, pointed out that "you can make many versions of a poster, or many editions of a print. People who are into DIY culture get really into printmaking. It's an accessible way to make creative things and make lots of them."

For people who are not inherently adept at using the computer, "exploring techniques through the analog can be really exciting," Herrera Soto said. And for people who enjoy mixing other media with printmaking, this combination can achieve a wide range of graphic expression.

One such printmaker who combines printmaking techniques with other media is Rob Sato. An LA-based artist, Sato creates hybrid prints, blending together screen printing and lithography—a process that involves etching on a flat stone—with watercolor and colored pencil. Full of vibrant and absurd images like toppled cars at a picnic, mushrooms sprouting out of fingertips, and gardens of colorful mazes, Sato's work makes you feel like you're in a dream that you wouldn't mind exploring for a while longer. In printmaking, Sato finds something magical in the tactile experience of books and paper. He admires how lithography can transfer the brittle texture of a graphite drawing. This technique both manipulates the original image and heightens its beauty. "It's a perfect imperfection," he said. "There's a tension there where you're trying to get it as perfect as possible but it'll never be. And that's super fun to me."

Sato is part of the Giant Robot universe, an Asian and Asian-American collective of visual artists and art lovers. Founded by Eric Nakamura in 1994, Giant Robot started off as a "punk-minded," stapled zine. Nakamura eventually launched the Giant Robot Store in the Sawtelle district of Los Angeles, a historically Japanese-American neighborhood. The second Giant Robot Store is a gallery space, where Sato had his first solo exhibition in 2009.

"[Printmaking] used to be a very industrial and practical process," Sato said. Recently, he has seen more experimentation with printmaking. With the proliferation of new, mainly digital technology that has replaced more analog traditions of handling production and distribution, printmaking has become an "almost entirely art practice." In some cases, the printmaking tradition is passed on from older generations of printmakers to younger artists. He described how Tiny Splendor, a printing collective in Oakland, just obtained a huge industrial press. Tiny Splendor inherited the press from an "old printer in San Francisco" who told the collective that "as long as you can get this out of here, you can have it for free." Sato has been seeing "a lot of these stories happening across the country, where these old litho stones are sitting in warehouses. But some old printer is saying, 'please, somebody take care of this.' And there are a few cases where young people are like, yeah I'm gonna take responsibility for this material and practice and carry it forward into the future."

Despite the slow pace and lack of instant gratification that comes with analog technology, younger artists continue to invest their time experimenting with printmaking mediums. Sato sees this resurgence as a clear reaction to the "over-digitization of the world."

"There's a tradition in [my] age group of making things yourself," said Sonya Sagan-Dworsky '26, an Intro Printmaking student. She grew up in a small town in Vermont with a mom who is both an artist and an architect. In the summers of her childhood, she would visit her mother's printmaking studio in rural Vermont, where her mother kept tubs of acid in the backyard. She remembers experimenting



"The Mask Collector"
3 color Risograph print by Rob Sato

with her first monotype print when she was seven years old, constructing collages out of scavenged wildflowers, thistles, and dandelions. With printmaking, Sonya has noticed that "you can't really take away a mistake." But she sees the benefit in making slip-ups. "It causes me to grow as an artist. I explore how to incorporate that [mistake] into the final design."

Some younger artists use screen printing to give "new life" to thrifted and vintage clothes. Charlotte Silverman, a senior at Brown University, prints original drawings on surfaces like canvas tote bags, workwear pants, and tank tops. She also enjoys using clothes that are supposed to be "fancy," such as button-ups or long skirts, and turning them into something funky and warped.

Silverman's daily ritual of drawing began in high school. Intimidated by the technicality of observational drawing, she was more interested in portraying "distorted versions of reality." During her first year in college, she took a water-based silkscreen class at the Rhode Island School of Design, where she worked for the first time with fabric screens and fabric ink. Screen printing was "a natural transition from drawing." After that class ended, she decided to pursue screen printing on her own. She would work from her home in Los Angeles, printing out of her closet and washing screens in her shower. The result was Fargo Street, Silverman's DIY clothing line that features hand-printed drawings. Fargo Street is a culmination of her two loves: drawing and fashion. Her drawings are surreal and playful, whether it's a wrestling match between ants or human(ish) figures with balloon-shaped heads spinning turntables and dancing around speakers. Her style is characterized by clean linework and meticulous dotwork, evoking the graininess of sandpaper or television screen static.

This past summer, Silverman organized and curated a weekly pop-up showroom in Los Angeles, featuring 18 artists and designers whose pieces she displayed in conversation with one another. She

Why are people still drawn to analog technology, when there are more streamlined ways to make art?

finds something special in meeting people through her art and seeing how people interact with her clothes. For Silverman, the best feeling is when someone expresses that "that [piece of clothing] is them." Once Silverman graduates in the spring, she hopes to pursue more sustainable ways of sourcing the clothing, such as hand-sewing clothes using vintage fabrics.

Reflecting on the evolution of Fargo Street, Silverman said that "the hands-on experience and all the little things that are tedious make it worthwhile."

Along with printmaking, analog art forms such as film photography have experienced a comeback in recent years. Like printmaking, film photography is a tedious artmaking process that does not always yield immediate results. From friends taking photos of each other on disposable cameras to students exploring how to develop photos in the darkroom, young artists are engaging with film photography in the same way that their parents or grandparents did.

The value of older photo technology is that "the photos become timeless," said Alan Lin '24. Lin is the head of the photo department for WYBC Yale Radio, the student-run radio station. He recently documented WYBC's annual homecoming event, shooting on a 35mm film camera to capture the crowd dancing and radio members posing. While most event photographers would opt to use digital cameras, Lin prefers the analog format. He likes the intentionality behind using film, where every single photo feels like a moment of decision. In comparison to digital photos, he finds the aesthetic of film photos more pleasing and organic, and he embraces their imperfections.

Why are people still drawn to analog technology, when there are more streamlined ways to make art? Lin noted that the artist's satisfaction should take precedence over the end product. Young people, said Lin, are "searching for a more intimate connection with music and fashion and artmaking."

Coming apart

FOR 17 YEARS, Joanna Lillis has worked in Kazakhstan as a journalist for publications like *The Guardian* and *The Economist*. She has become one of the foremost writers covering Central Asian affairs and is the author of a book on the complex Kazakh political system.

Yet Lillis has never seen Kazakhstan like this. When she glances out of her window, thousands of new faces pass by on the streets below.

"It's obvious where I am in Almaty, Kazakhstan's largest city, because you can just see that there are more Russians around on the street," Lillis said.

Following Russia's invasion of Ukraine, hundreds of thousands of Russian migrants poured into neighboring countries in Eastern Europe

and Central Asia. This influx has impacted Central Asian politics and culture, and Kazakhstan in particular has received a dramatic flood of new Russian residents.

Kazakhstan and Russia have had a long-standing and intimate relationship. Rus' people first began to populate present-day Kazakhstan in the 16th century, and cultural, social, religious, and economic ties endured. The Russian language and culture have a notable presence in Kazakhstan to this day.

The recent migration is undoubtedly the largest move of Russian people into Kazakhstan since the Soviet Union dissolved. Migrants are often either young Russian men evading military conscription or politically-conscientious objectors to

Central Asia's Shifting Ties with Russia

BY **PHOENIX BOGGS**

“We have to remember that the
Central Asian nations, for the lo
and Belarus, have lived under th
happen to them.”

Russia’s unlawful invasion. Lillis laughed as she talked about the differences between the new Russian migrants and the Kazakh people. While the two can be difficult to tell apart by physical features alone, Lillis said that identifying the difference is remarkably easy.

“There are all kinds of funny stories that people are telling, saying, ‘Oh, I know they were Russian because of X Y, Z,” she said. “People know because Russians can’t pronounce the name of the currency, for example. It’s pronounced ‘tin-gher,’ but they pronounce it ‘ten-gay.’ And friends of mine were joking that you would only see Russians wear shorts and sandals in October.”

On the whole, the Central Asian response to this influx has been relatively warm. Kazakhs, according to Lillis, are largely sympathetic to the Russian migrants and have welcomed their new neighbors. This is especially true in cases where Russians have made an effort to assimilate into their host cultures.

“We see some of the more sensitive Russians actually joining Kazakh language clubs. Some of the new arrivals are trying to learn a bit of Kazakh,” Lillis said.

However, the Russians who make the effort to get involved in cultural efforts such as Kazakh language clubs are perhaps a minority. Many Russian migrants do not see the need to assimilate into Kazakh culture—an outlook that can spark resentment.

“Russians tend to have quite a colonial mentality about the use of Russian and tend to just blast away in Russian, impervious to what effect they are having on people. And these things are so very sensitive,” Lillis said.

Indeed, this colonial mentality has a long history. Claire Roosien, a Yale professor who teaches in the Slavic Languages and Literatures Department and specializes in modern Eurasia, emphasized that the history of the Soviet Union has left many Russians with a lingering colonial mindset.

“Throughout the Soviet period, if you were Russian, you were entitled to speak Russian anywhere in the Soviet Union. There was a real sense of colonial entitlement on the part of Russian speakers,” Roosien said. “That kind of mentality seems to persist even among the people who are currently fleeing to Central Asia. Despite their opposition-mindedness, in some cases, they tend to hold on to long-standing colonial entitlement.”

Russian migration into Kazakhstan, however, has transformed more than just Kazakhstan’s culture. It has had real practical effects on the Kazakh people and economy, too. Leyla Latypova, an independent journalist who writes about Russian affairs, emphasized that there are marked economic distinctions between the new Russian migrants and many of those living in Central Asia.

“Russians who do have the opportunity to leave the country—they have money. The most vulnerable groups from the villages, they cannot possibly escape mobilization or the draft like that,” Latypova said. “So it’s mostly groups like Russian IT [workers]. That’s the prime emigration group, and they get paid very well.”

The arrival of tens of thousands of wealthy Russian emigrants in countries like

Soviet Union was an empire. ongest time, just like Ukraine his fear that something might

Kazakhstan has caused massive economic upheaval. Because of their relative wealth, these migrants can pay more for housing and goods than many local Kazakhs. In response to the influx, Kazakhstan's central bank has raised interest rates to their highest level in six years in an attempt to curb skyrocketing inflation.

The economic turmoil is also affecting Kazakhs in their homes. Suddenly, people who have lived in apartments for their whole lives are being evicted in favor of wealthier Russian tenants. Lillis has seen this effect firsthand in Almaty.

"The rent price rises have been massive. They went up by about 25 to 30% in the northern towns along the border in the immediate aftermath of the Ukrainian invasion," Lillis said. "There is lots of anecdotal evidence of people being thrown out of their flats to make room for Russians who can pay more. I know people this has happened to. Landlords say, 'Right, you're out tomorrow, because I have a better client.'"

Kazakhs also worry that the housing market will affect the entire population, including younger generations. In particular, young people seeking educational opportunities have been unable to find housing, forcing them to leave school.

"Students have been evicted, lots of them," Lillis said. "Almaty is a big student town. I've heard of people not being able to pursue their studies because they have to leave the city and go to their parents. They can't afford to live here."

Rent hikes may only be the tip of the financial iceberg. Lillis noted that Kazakhs are also concerned about the migrants' effects on the job market. While some Russians are choosing to continue teleworking for their Russian jobs, Kazakhs fear that some will have to take jobs in Central Asia.

"People like electricians, hairdressers, you can't do that by distance. So there will be pressure also on the job market. And the people are worried about that," Lillis said.

Latypova and Lillis both feel that this economic tension will have great long-term repercussions. Inflation caused by the Russian invasion of Ukraine may prevent Kazakhs from paying for necessary goods, leaving many without homes and essentials. These domestic economic hardships may reshape Central Asian governments' complex policy toward Russia.

THE DYNAMIC between Russia and Kazakhstan—in fact, between Russia and most of Central Asia—has long been defined by both reliance and fear. Central Asian countries are constantly aware of their tenuous position as former Soviet territories, and they worry about renewed aggression from their powerful neighbor to the north.

These fears are not unfounded. The war in Ukraine is not the first instance of Russian incursion into former Soviet territory. Russia also launched attacks against Georgia in 2008 and Crimea in 2014. Some scholars argue that the Ukrainian invasion is part of a legacy of Russian attempts to reconstitute the Soviet Union in Central Asia. The Ukrainian invasion is part of this trend—one that worries some Central Asian policymakers.

"We have to remember that the Sovi-

et Union was an empire. Central Asian nations, for the longest time, just like Ukraine and Belarus, have lived under this fear that something might happen to them," Latypova said. After the invasion, she added, "there is of course solidarity with Ukrainian people, but then there is also being, like, 'Oh, my God, they're literally at our border too. What precludes them from coming toward us?'"

Nonetheless, the fear that characterizes this relationship is only part of the story. It works in tandem with a long history of partnership and reliance. Central Asia and Russia are inexorably tied—culturally, historically, and practically.

"Central Asian republics are very, very dependent on Russia. It's a legacy of the Soviet period," Roosien said. "For example, a huge part of the Tajikistan economy is remittances from migrant workers in Russia. Central Asian governments depend on the Russian military for training and equipment. And a lot of Central Asian governments are dependent on both Russia and Ukraine for grain imports, so they don't want to completely alienate themselves from Russia."

The Ukrainian invasion has had a double effect. On one hand, it heightened the fear that has always permeated Central Asian-Russian relations. But it has also undermined some of the region's ability to depend on its imperial neighbor. Kazakhstan's reliance on Russia has historically been motivated by economic need. However, because of the Ukrainian invasion, Russia's capacity to provide economic aid to Central Asia has declined. Western sanctions have further limited its resources. Central Asian leaders question whether Russia will be able to offer the same economic assistance and assurance that it once could.

"A lot of the fear on the part of [Central Asian] government officials seems to be not just 'Will Russia invade?' but actually the reverse: 'Will Russia's invasion of Ukraine take away from resources that we've been getting from Russia?'" Roosien said.

Central Asian countries have already taken some subtle steps toward creating distance in their relationship with Russia. At the United Nations General Assembly meeting on March 2, no Central Asian country endorsed Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Since then, Kazakhstan and other Central Asian countries have also refused to return Russian migrants who fled the draft.

At a summit on Central Asian issues on October 14, the president of Tajikistan launched into a seven-minute tirade lambasting Russia for its lack of "respect" for Tajikistan and other Central Asian countries. It was a major step in signaling defiance against Russia. The speech was an outpouring of frustration, and many pundits took it as a serious sign that Asian policymakers were fed up with Moscow.

"I don't want to exaggerate the pivot away, but there's definitely a reorientation of foreign policy . . . And it's very obvious," Lillis said. "I think what's really driving the distance between Russia and Kazakhstan is a concern by the president and his team about the potential repercussions of the war in Ukraine for respect for borders in the post-Soviet region, which Russia has torn up."

Amid these stories, it is important to remember that this shift remains subtle. Central Asia is far from ready to completely denounce its historical patron. The ties between the two regions are still strong.

"We should not underestimate the linguistic, cultural, and historical influence Russia has had," Lillis said. "There are many ethnic Russians in Kazakhstan and in the wider Central Asian region who don't want to cut ties."

In fact, some have viewed the president of Tajikistan's rant differently, noting that the president was not demanding independence or greater autonomy from Russia. Rather, he was pleading for more Russian support.

"The tirade has been interpreted in different ways: both as evidence of resistance against Putin and also as an expression of dependency on Putin," Roosien said. "He was begging Putin for more resources and more support."

Roosien argued that Central Asian countries are not simply bucking their Russian ally. Instead, she feels that Central Asian policymakers are keeping their options open, making sure not to upset any potential future patrons.

"They want to stay on everyone's good side. Many Central Asian governments are dependent on Russia, but they're also dependent on China, and they're dependent on the West, and they want to maintain good relationships with all of these countries," Roosien said. "As Russia becomes more and more of a pariah, they need to distance themselves from Russia to the extent that they can in order to maintain friendly relations with other countries. It's been a very delicate balancing act."

IF CENTRAL ASIA AND RUSSIA continue to drift apart, some have predicted that other powers could step in. To Latypova, the United States and other NATO-allied countries are major contenders. Turkey may also look to expand its influence.

"[Turkey's President] Erdogan is very smart and witty when it comes to his whole idea of Pan-Turkism. Turkey does have much more to offer than most of the partners in the region. I think we need to really watch that space and see if they will try to weigh in and do something," Latypova said.

Meanwhile, many see China, with its geographical positioning in the region as well as its growing economic and political power, as the natural successor to Russia's legacy. "I do see China getting stronger [in the region]," Lillis said. "In recent diplomatic visits in our region involving Xi Jinping and Putin, we saw that Xi looked more powerful, and Putin looked on the backfoot."

It is uncertain whether a new power will take Russia's place. Many Kazakhs and Central Asians at large still retain favorable views toward Russia. One Almaty poll conducted in July 2022 found that 39% of Kazakhs approved of Russia's military campaigns. Only 10% expressed solidarity with Ukraine. No matter what Central Asian policy makers feel about their historic partner, most citizens express support for closer ties with Moscow.

The future of the partnership between Russia and Central Asia is unclear. Russia's invasion of Ukraine and its effects demonstrate the complex nature of the alliances.

Between Yale and Net Zero

Yale's Power Plants Pose a Climate Challenge

BY **ANDREW ALAM-NIST**

Although wealthy countries and rich institutions such as change, its impacts tend to across the globe

"WE ARE DRIVING OFF A CLIFF and need radical change," said Chris Schweitzer, the head of the New Haven Climate Movement, a grassroots climate justice organization. "Yale has two massive power plants, each running off natural gas, that each produce 100,000 tons of greenhouse gasses."

Criticisms of Yale's environmental policies have often focused on its endowment. Groups such as the Endowment Justice Coalition have urged Yale to divest the endowment from fossil fuels. However, Yale's energy production itself has largely been ignored. At the center of campus, the two monolithic stacks of the Central Power Plant stand hidden in plain sight, powering the main campus with gas. Although weaning Yale off its fossil fuel dependency might be difficult, activists like Schweitzer are advocating that the university make this shift soon.

Schweitzer is a New Haven resident who has long been an activist. His focus on climate change began in 1998 when Hurricane Mitch, a Category 5 hurricane, brought untold devastation to Nicaragua. Since 1984, Schweitzer had worked on a sister project to build ties between New Haven and Leon, a small town in Nicaragua. The project has worked to improve life in Leon by promoting sustainable development, investing in education, and seeking to eradicate poverty.

Hurricane Mitch undid the sister project's work in a matter of days.

The hurricane on average brought 50 inches of rain, an unprecedented level that led to widespread flooding, mudslides, and landslides. As the land slid away, communities often followed. An estimated 3,800 people were killed by the disaster across the country. Schweitzer witnessed this destruction on a trip to Leon shortly after the disaster.

"All the people in those communities lost their land, lost their houses, lost their cows, lost everything, and so they just start all over again," he said. "What that means for the mothers and the children who had to go through that trauma, and extra poverty and hunger and impact on their educations, is pretty significant."

The hurricanes that Schweitzer witnessed in Leon are made far more destructive by climate change. Estimates from the University of Wisconsin suggest that anthropogenic climate change causes hurricanes to be 25% stronger on average than base levels. This is accompanied by a 5-10% increase in wind speeds.

When hurricanes or large storms hit Yale, their effects are normally mere inconveniences. In September 2021, Hurricane Ida flooded Marsh Hall, shut down several dining halls, and moved classes onto Zoom. Yale bounced back from all these disruptions in a matter of days. This resilience is something that Nicaragua's physical and economic infrastructure precludes.

"If you're impoverished and have just enough money for basic food for the year, and then the storm comes along and takes whatever you have, it's not, 'Let me pull up to my church or live with my uncle at the beach and hang out.' You're displaced," Schweitzer said. Many Nicaraguans, who only made marginally enough money to afford food and shelter, were, in Schweitzer's words, "screwed."

Witnessing the destruction of entire communities in Nicaragua brought into focus for Schweitzer the threat that climate change poses to humanity. Although wealthy countries like the United States and rich institutions such as Yale often drive climate change, its impacts tend to fall on the poorest across the globe. While decarbonization is a nice goal with distant consequences for Yale, it is a necessity for much of the developing world.

"We can see climate change undermining everything we're doing to try to reduce poverty in Nicaragua," said Sch-

like the United States Yale often drive climate fall on the poorest

weitzer. "We just see this as an existential threat for many, many people on Earth."

In his role as the head of the New Haven Climate Movement, Schweitzer has tried to combat this existential threat. He has pushed for bike lanes, robust climate education, and electrification in New Haven. "We know it's a climate emergency, and we need urgent action. We're not waiting until 2030 or 2050," Schweitzer said. "We need people to make really serious cuts in greenhouse gasses. Now."

As part of his push to electrify New Haven, Schweitzer has focused extensively on Yale. Schweitzer emphasized that, for all Yale's wealth, it still heavily relies on and invests in fossil fuels. "I think the fact that they know they know about it and they have the resources to really do something makes it worse," he said.

THE CHIMNEYS OF YALE'S 15-megawatt Central Power Plant poke out over the New Haven skyline across the road from Ezra Stiles and Morse Colleges. The plant provides electricity to most of Yale's main campus, while 20-megawatt Sterling Power Plant largely powers the Yale School of Medicine.

Yale's plants are very thermally efficient, operating at 79% thermal efficiency compared to an average of 49.9% efficiency for general, non-cogenerative power plants. This means that they produce less greenhouse gasses than a comparable gas-fired power plant. Nevertheless, their use of gas poses significant problems.

The plants produce significantly greater emissions than equivalent renewable energy sources. Yale's energy production releases 175,000 megatons of carbon dioxide per year. If Yale were to rely entirely on renewables, carbon dioxide emissions from campus activities could fall to nearly zero. This shift could halt Yale's contribution to the growth of extreme weather events such as Hurricane Mitch.

Some of Yale's peer schools have already made the transition to renewable power sources. More than 40 American colleges and universities now produce their energy entirely from renewables. Stanford University has transitioned to 100% renewable energy production, with the imminent goal of the campus becoming carbon-neutral.

While Yale does have ten renewable wind-powered turbines atop the Becton Center, the importance of these turbines is limited. Yale installed the turbines mostly as an educational experiment. As per Yale's sustainability reports, each wind-powered turbine only produces one-thousandth of the power of a single steam-based turbine from the Central Power Plant. This amounts to only about one percent of the Becton Center's energy production.

Andy Bromage, a representative from the Yale Office of Sustainability, emphasized the importance of a solar plant that exists on West Campus. "The West Campus Solar Array, which began operating in 2015, is a 1.34-megawatt installation that generates one-fifth of West Campus' energy demand," Bromage said. However, the amount of energy produced by the West Campus Solar Array is relatively insignificant on a campus-wide scale — it amounts to less than a tenth of the energy produced by either of Yale's major fossil fuels plants.

The only building on the Yale campus that is exultantly green is Kroon Hall, the building for the School of Environment. Completed in 2009 at a cost of $33.5 million dollars, Kroon Hall employed state-of-the-art climate measures throughout its construction.

Kroon Hall is designed to be powered entirely by renewable energy. It uses a mixture of geothermal and solar technology. It also employs a spate of measures to improve energy efficiency. These include

Some of Yale's peer schools have already made the transition to renewable power sources. More than 40 American colleges and universities now produce their energy entirely from renewables.

thick concrete walls to insulate the building from variations in temperature and an innovative heat energy recovery system. The building is intended to consume 67% less energy than a building of comparable size.

Although Kroon Hall represents the potential of Yale's environmental prowess, the building is still an anomaly. "Kroon Hall is the one building that they've done anything close to being passive or not creating more needs for fossil fuels," Schweitzer said. In contrast, he added, "the School of Management is a huge energy hog."

While it is easy to criticize Yale for not switching to renewable energy, it is significantly harder to explain how it should do so. Two of the most feasible alternatives to the Yale power plants—using geothermal energy or relying on the Connecticut grid—are both flawed.

"The problem is that there is no existing technology from which you could build an equivalent new power plant that would run on either … geothermal or external electric power," said Daniel Prober, the Director of Undergraduate Studies for Applied Physics.

Geothermal, as used in Kroon Hall, faces significant challenges. On a simple level, it is not an especially well-understood technology. "Geothermal is not proved anywhere in an existing 10,000 or 20,000-person operation," Prober emphasized. The boring of holes for geothermal and its withdrawal of heat from the Earth also risks causing small earthquakes, a disaster waiting to happen in New Haven.

The Connecticut grid itself, conversely, is reliant primarily on fossil fuels, which account for 55% of its energy production. As such, the grid is presently only marginally cleaner than Yale's own power plants.

The use of power from the grid would also prevent Yale from self-sufficiently producing its energy. Energy companies drawing from the New Haven grid would provide Yale with interruptible contracts. These contracts mean that since Yale is an institution that has the capacity to be self-sufficient, companies are able to withdraw power from the campus in periods of exceptionally high demand.

Even minor interruptions in Yale's energy supply would be disruptive to the community. Given the time that it would take to evacuate campus, students could be marooned on the campus for days without basic utilities.

"If the campus system failed, you couldn't even send home all the students in six or ten hours," Prober explained.

If Yale lost its energy, it could disrupt research projects as well. "We have labs that have to be supplied with heating and cooling, laboratory animals, cell samples," Prober continued.

Gas, while a flawed method of energy production, is consistent. The technology is well-understood and Yale keeps three-day emergency stores of fossil fuels that could power the entire campus. The use of gas thus, for now, allows Yale the reliability in its energy production that protects its students, faculty, and research.

Schweitzer disagreed with Prober's assessment. "There's always groups like ISO New England, their whole job is to manage power supply and make sure there is sufficient power. And the utilities get paid extra money … to pay for these extremely expensive generators for backup use four times a year. I have a hard time thinking that they couldn't manage enough electricity to keep Yale's campus going."

Moreover, Schweitzer fails to see why Yale needs to be completely self-sufficient. "The [Connecticut] grid will be 90% clean by 2025," Schweitzer emphasized. To him, this means that Yale has an imperative to switch to it.

Retiring Yale's central power plant would require the full electrification of the campus. This would entail a near-total overhaul of the campus facilities. With the exception of Yale's newest buildings, the campus's infrastructure is reliant on gas and fossil fuels. To change this would be a daunting prospect.

"There's no technology based on electricity that could run the university today without a huge multibillion-dollar redesign of almost all the buildings," Prober noted.

Despite this difficulty, Yale has devoted itself to decarbonizing its campus. The University has committed itself to achieving net zero carbon emissions by 2035 and actual zero emissions by 2050.

Achieving this goal may require phasing out reliance on the Central Power Plant. However, it is unclear whether Yale can easily do so. Even with the money and technology, this task remains difficult.

"A really big issue with the availability of the workforce to just doing the actual work," said Casey Pickett, the head of Yale Carbon Charge, a university-affiliated initiative to test the feasibility of carbon pricing on campus.

CARBON CHARGE IS COMMITTED to reforming the campus in smaller ways. Pickett described the initiative's mission as "a scheme that charges buildings on the campus for each metric tonne of carbon they produce." The goal of the project is to incentivize buildings to switch to renewable energy.

The changes Carbon Charge has brought have been small, but nevertheless significant.

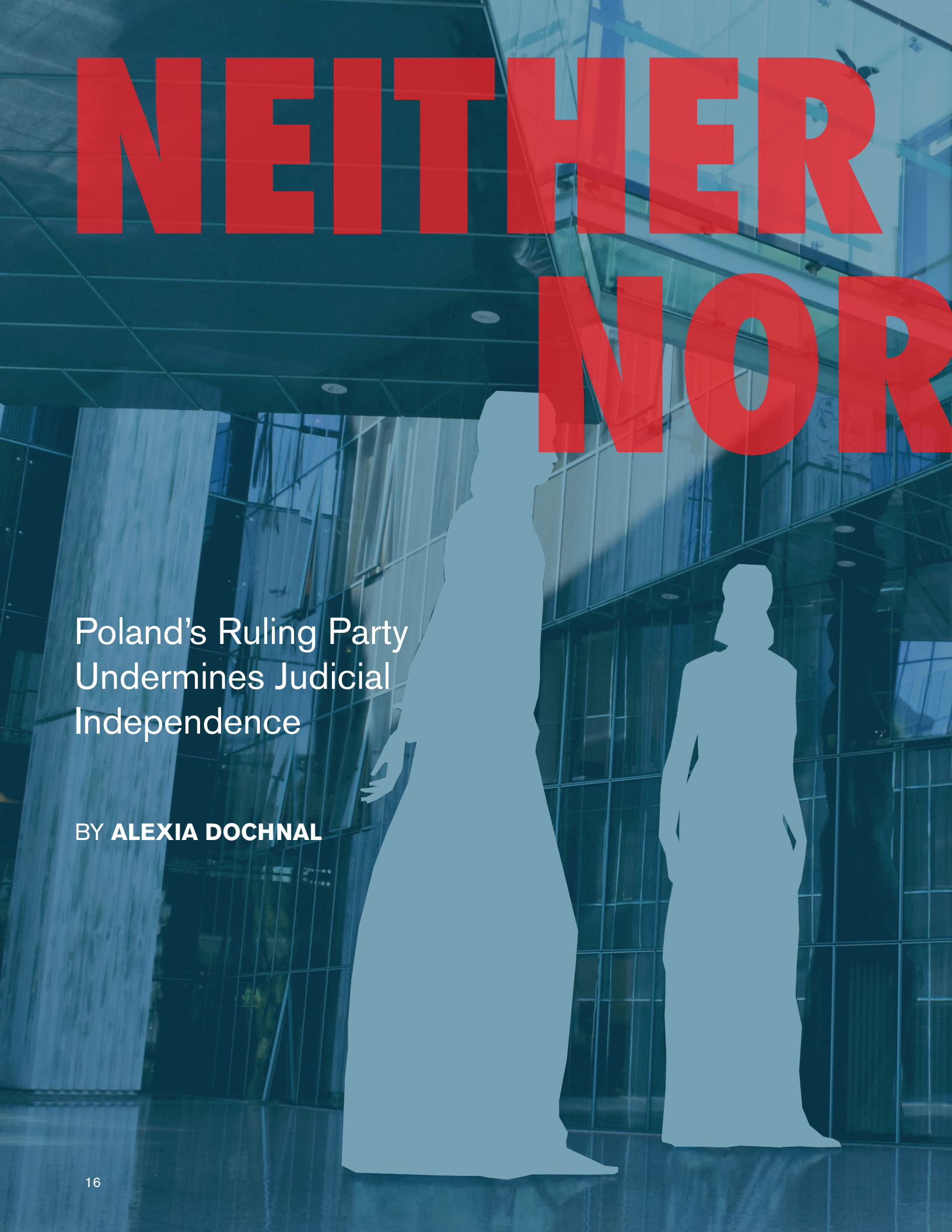
The School of Management now turns its jumbotron screens off by 8PM instead of 11PM. When the School of Forestry, now the Yale School of the Environment, was preparing to replace a boiler in one of its buildings, Carbon Charge showed them how they could save money in the long term if they invested in the more efficient boiler option (although the option was more expensive over the short-term).

Carbon Charge is not a panacea. It will not free Yale of the fossil fuels produced by its two main power plants. However, it does represent one of many steps Yale has taken to concretely try to achieve its net-zero goal by 2035.

Transitioning to renewable energy will be a daunting project. There are many significant roadblocks to electrification and achieving net zero. However, every year that Yale does not transition to green energy, it continues to contribute to climate change. "To say they're going to close [the power plants] in 20 years means hundreds of thousands of tons of greenhouse gasses per year," Schweitzer said.

In the meantime, communities like Leon will continue to be affected by hurricanes and other natural disasters worsened by climate change. While Yale can plan decades in advance to mitigate these effects, low-income communities such as Leon cannot. Individual farmers, when their homes are wiped out and livelihoods destroyed, have little way to adapt.

"At some point, the Earth just can't take all this damage," Schweitzer said.



NEITHER NOR

Poland's Ruling Party Undermines Judicial Independence

BY **ALEXIA DOCHNAL**

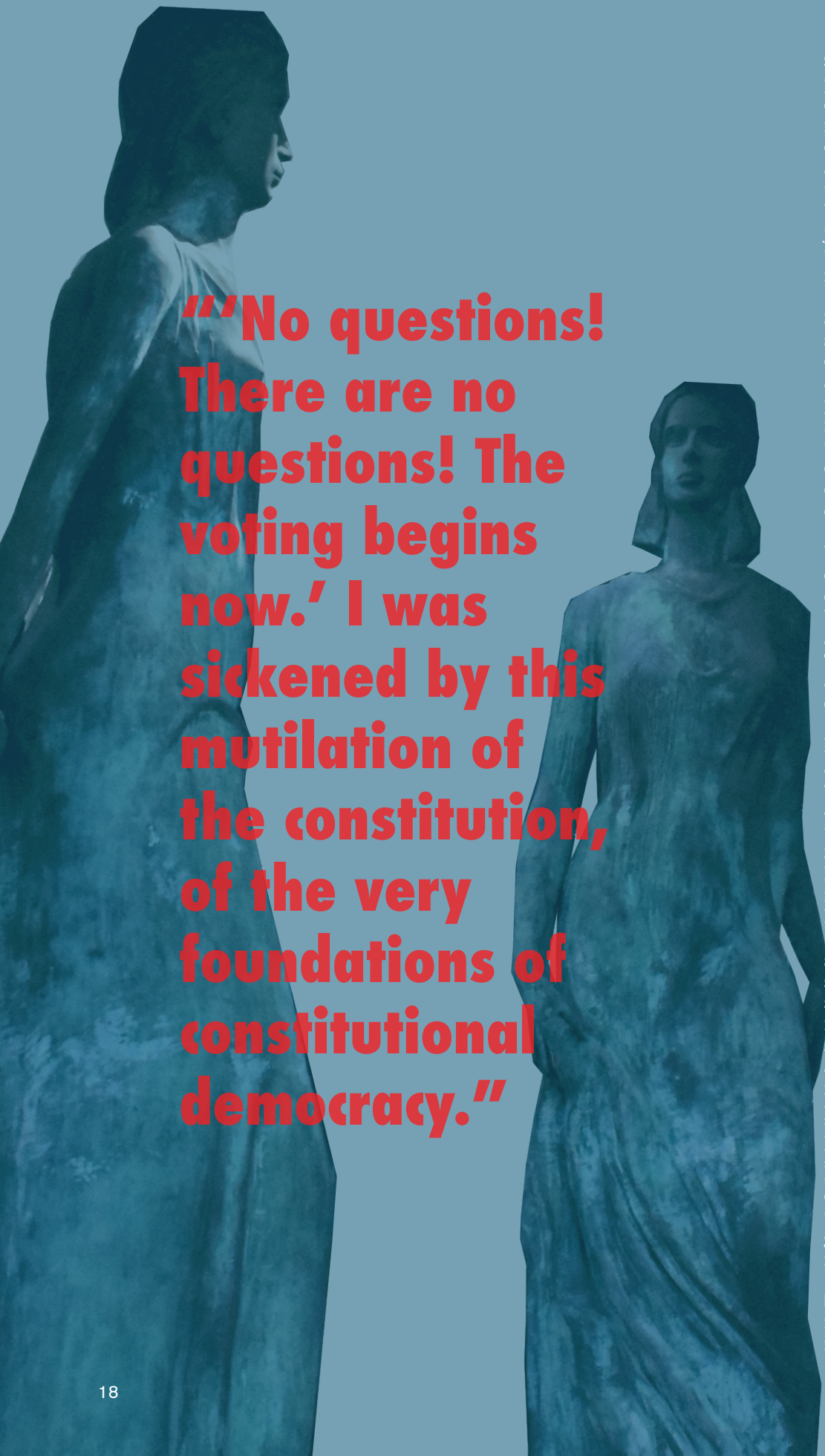
LAW & JUSTICE



IN 2019, Poland's state TV broadcaster, Telewizja Polska S.A. (TVP), accused Wojciech Sadurski of criminal defamation over a tweet. A dual citizen of Poland and Australia, Sadurski is Challis Professor of Jurisprudence at the University of Sydney. In recent years, he has faced a number of defamation cases for his criticism of Poland's ruling party, Prawo i Sprawiedliwość (PiS), or Law and Justice.

Sadurski's first defamation case was initiated by the leader of PiS, Jarosław Kaczyński. The other two defamation cases—one criminal and one civil—were launched by TVP. Although TVP "describes itself as a public television broadcaster," Sadurski noted that it "is in reality fully controlled by the government." Since the Polish government controls TVP, the suits against Sadurski were widely recognized as amounting to state repression.

"It's a way of trying to muzzle me, to silence me," Sadurski said. "And to create what we lawyers, under the First Amendment of the U.S. Constitution, call the 'chilling effect.' They want to chill their critics. And they want to chill me."



"'No questions! There are no questions! The voting begins now.' I was sickened by this mutilation of the constitution, of the very foundations of constitutional democracy."

SADURSKI HAS ALREADY WON two proceedings in the criminal defamation case launched against him by TVP, prevailing both at the Court of First Instance, the court that hears a case for the first time, and at the Court of Appeal, a higher court that reviews the original court's decision. Under the normal procedure of the Polish judicial system, Sadurski noted that these two victories would have entailed a "definite and final judgment."

However, TVP decided to appeal Sadurski's case in a process called cassation, hoping that the ruling would be overturned. A cassation appeal calls for a higher court (in Poland's case, the Supreme Court) to conduct an extraordinary review of a legal case. For such a review to take place, there must be proof of a major error in initial court proceedings or proof of newly emerged facts that change the case's situation drastically.

Ten years ago, Sadurski would have been confident that his case would not qualify for extraordinary cassation. However, the Polish Supreme Court is not the body it once was. Sadurski said that since about half of the Court now consists of "new judges who have been improperly appointed and who are controlled by the executive," he has no idea what lies ahead.

The outcome of Sadurski's case hinges entirely on which judge will be appointed to oversee his case. A judge with strong ties to the ruling party may attempt to reopen the case, even though there is no legal basis for such a decision. Sadurski noted that even in today's Poland, this remains unlikely. If such a scenario does occur, however, it could "make legal history."

Since taking power in 2015, PiS has sought increasing control over the Polish state. According to Sadurski, PiS has asserted authority over state-owned business, public media, civil and diplomatic services, law enforcement, and, partly, academia. In Sadurski's words, there remain only a few isolated "islands of independence" in Poland today. These include local governments in major cities, independent and underfunded NGOs, and, at least right now, the judicial system. Yet the current government is determined to strip the judiciary of its independence, a struggle that will shape the future of democratic rule in Poland.

LOCATING A SPECIFIC starting point in the decline of judicial independence in Poland is a near-impossible task. Ewa

Łętowska, Professor of Legal Science at the University of Warsaw, Poland's first Ombudsman for Citizen Rights (1988-92), and judge of the Polish Constitutional Tribunal (2002-2011), noted that in a process as distressing and convoluted as the Polish government's attacks on the judiciary, "it is very difficult to point to an initial point, to a culminating point, and to the point in which we currently stand." However, Łętowska identified the government's restructuring of the Polish Constitutional Tribunal, which began in 2016, as a crucial moment in the trajectory.

The Constitutional Tribunal is Poland's constitutional court. Its chief tasks are to pinpoint and resolve inconsistencies between the Polish Constitution and the actions of the government, and to regulate the power of the executive branch. Because of its oversight capacity, the Constitutional Tribunal poses a significant threat to a government whose rule involves, in the words of Sadurski, a "great number of unlawful actions, including unlawful breaches of the Constitution."

In 2016, the Sejm, the lower chamber of the Polish Parliament, passed a series of "Repair Acts" directed at the Constitutional Tribunal. These acts reorganized the Tribunal and gave veto power to newly appointed judges aligned with the ruling party. Many Polish lawmakers never fully understood what the acts actually entailed, an uncertainty which exemplified PiS's opaque strategy to master the court.

Professor Andrzej Rzepliński of the University of Warsaw, President of the Constitutional Tribunal from 2010 to 2016, described the process of voting on these acts, at which he was present, as a violation of democratic principles.

"Two or three Members of Parliament wanted to ask a question or seek clarification regarding the content of the Repair Acts, which in a functioning constitutional democracy should be natural . . . In response, Marshal Kuchciński [Chairman of the Sejm, 2015-2019] shouted, 'No questions! There are no questions! The voting begins now.' I was sickened by this mutilation of the constitution, of the very foundations of constitutional democracy."

Rzepliński noted that beyond their content, the Repair Acts signaled a general disdain for the Constitutional Tribunal by those in power. Before and during his presidency, it was an accepted practice for the Tribunal to present annual reports of its findings to the Polish Parliament. This practice ensured "necessary dialogue among the judicial, executive, and legislative branches of the country," he said. From 2015 onwards, however, Rzepliński "saw all of this wither away." By the end of his term, very few members of the Sejm listened to the report. "Out of 460 members, only a few dozen were present," Rzepliński said.

Sadurski said that in recent years, "there have been a number of absolutely aberrational judgments by the Constitutional Tribunal, which have even further reduced the scope of independence necessary for the judicial function." In December 2021, the European Union (EU) accused the Constitutional Tribunal of breaching EU law, signifying that the Polish government's reforms have eroded the Tribunal's international authority as well as its independence.

Following the Repair Acts on the Constitutional Tribunal, PiS advanced a web of laws passed in 2017 that restricted other elements of the Polish judiciary. Freedom House, an organization that tracks democratic trends worldwide, published a brief explaining the evolution of these laws.

The 2017 laws gave the Polish Parliament the right to appoint members of the National Council of the Judiciary (KRS). The chief task of the KRS is to nominate Polish judges. By appointing members of the KRS, the Parliament effectively gained the right to choose Polish judges themselves. Before the 2017 change, the judges of the KRS were nominated from within the Polish judiciary. Rzepliński, who wrote the 1989 law that established the original system of appointment, called its decline "an enormous problem for the whole of Europe."

The 2017 laws also lowered the age of mandatory retirement for Supreme Court judges and gave the president of Poland the right to appoint the Court president. These measures allowed PiS to replace a large portion of the Supreme Court with judges favorable to their party.

Professor John Morijn of the University of Groningen noted that these reforms threaten the Supreme Court's status as a legal body. "A court, in legal terms, is something that by definition is only composed of independent and impartial individuals," said Morijn. "If you put political appointees there, who clearly have a political agenda, they cannot be judges, and therefore this is not a court."

The 2017 laws also targeted regional courts by giving the Minister of Justice, Zbigniew Ziobro, control over the selec-



Ziobro is also the leader of Solidarna Polska, or United Poland, a smaller party within Poland's ruling coalition. Morijn noted that this party is "very anti-European and even more orthodox and radical" than PiS. According to Morijn, some experts believe that this party, although a junior partner in the ruling coalition, is behind some of the more extreme changes made to Poland's judicial system in recent years.

Although the early reforms in 2016 and 2017 had already begun to transform the judicial system, Professor Daniel Kelemen of Rutgers University argued that "the attacks on the judiciary in Poland have only intensified over time."

In recent years, a number of judges have been illegally appointed to Polish courts, including the Supreme Court. Sadurski explained that the term "illegally appointed" refers to appointments made under the recommendation of the National Council of the Judiciary. Since the Council's independence has been compromised by the 2017 laws, its appointments can no longer be considered lawful.

Another distressing reform was the government's establishment of a "Disciplinary Chamber" within the Supreme Court. This chamber, composed of newly appointed judges alone, served to "discipline" or punish judges who had supposedly violated the Court's expected standards of conduct, prohibiting judges from exercising their independence.

A number of judges have been removed from their positions by the Disciplinary Chamber. One notable example is Judge Igor Tuleya, whom the Chamber suspended in November 2020. Tuleya's case achieved international recognition as an example of political interference in the Polish judiciary. He has since become a symbol of popular resistance against the government's tactics.

In a further attempt to silence judges, the government enacted the "muzzle law," which came into force in January 2020. This punitive law prevents judges from performing a number of key judicial functions, such as "participating in the EU legal system and sending cases to the European Court of Justice," said Kelemen.

THE POLISH JUDICIARY has become an increasingly isolated body within the European legal system. In November 2021, the European Commission declared that it would look into applying "a new instrument" in both Poland and Hungary, said Morijn, which establishes compliance with rule of law as a precondition for receiving money from the EU. The Commission stated that Poland would not receive its post-pandemic recovery fund of approximately 38 billion dollars until it fulfilled a set of milestones aiming to restore judicial independence within the country. These milestones include reinstating judges who were removed from their positions for political reasons and dismantling the Disciplinary Chamber of the Supreme Court.

This summer, the European Commission announced its approval of Poland's National Recovery Plan, marking a step towards releasing the frozen funds—a decision that has received substantial criticism within the legal community.

In September 2022, four umbrella organizations of European judges challenged the legality of the decision, declaring that the issue of judicial independence in Poland has not yet been resolved. The judges argued that complying with basic standards of rule of law should simply be a "given" for any EU member state, and should not be subject to any "financial award," noted Morijn.

The steps that the Polish government has thus far taken to demonstrate its compliance with the EU milestones "change institutions only in name but not in nature," said Sadurski. For example, Poland dismantled the Disciplinary Chamber of the Supreme Court in July 2022, only to replace it with a new Chamber of Professional Responsibility. These changes served as a superficial display of compliance rather than a genuine attempt at restoring judicial independence.

In spite of the criticism that its decision has received, the European Commission remains one of few international bodies that can hold Poland accountable for its attacks on the judiciary. According to Sadurski, the Commission is "an important asset for defenders of the rule of law in Poland." The real issue lies with "the attitude, the response by the government and by the president [of Poland]," he said.

Whether or not Poland will succeed in receiving its frozen funds remains uncertain. The outcome of its attempts at unfreezing the money, however, could yield powerful implications for the future of rule of law in Europe at large.

Kelemen noted that the assaults on judicial independence in Poland have been "spreading to other states," with "worrying signs of backsliding in places like Bulgaria and Romania." As Poland is a prime example of an EU member state whose actions clearly contradict rule of law standards, its success in receiving funds from the EU could send an emboldening message to European countries following a similar path.

WHILE THE THREATS to judicial independence in Poland have consequences for the rest of Europe, Polish citizens bear the heaviest burden. Citizens across the country now face the same kind of uncertainty that Sadurski experienced during his defamation trials.

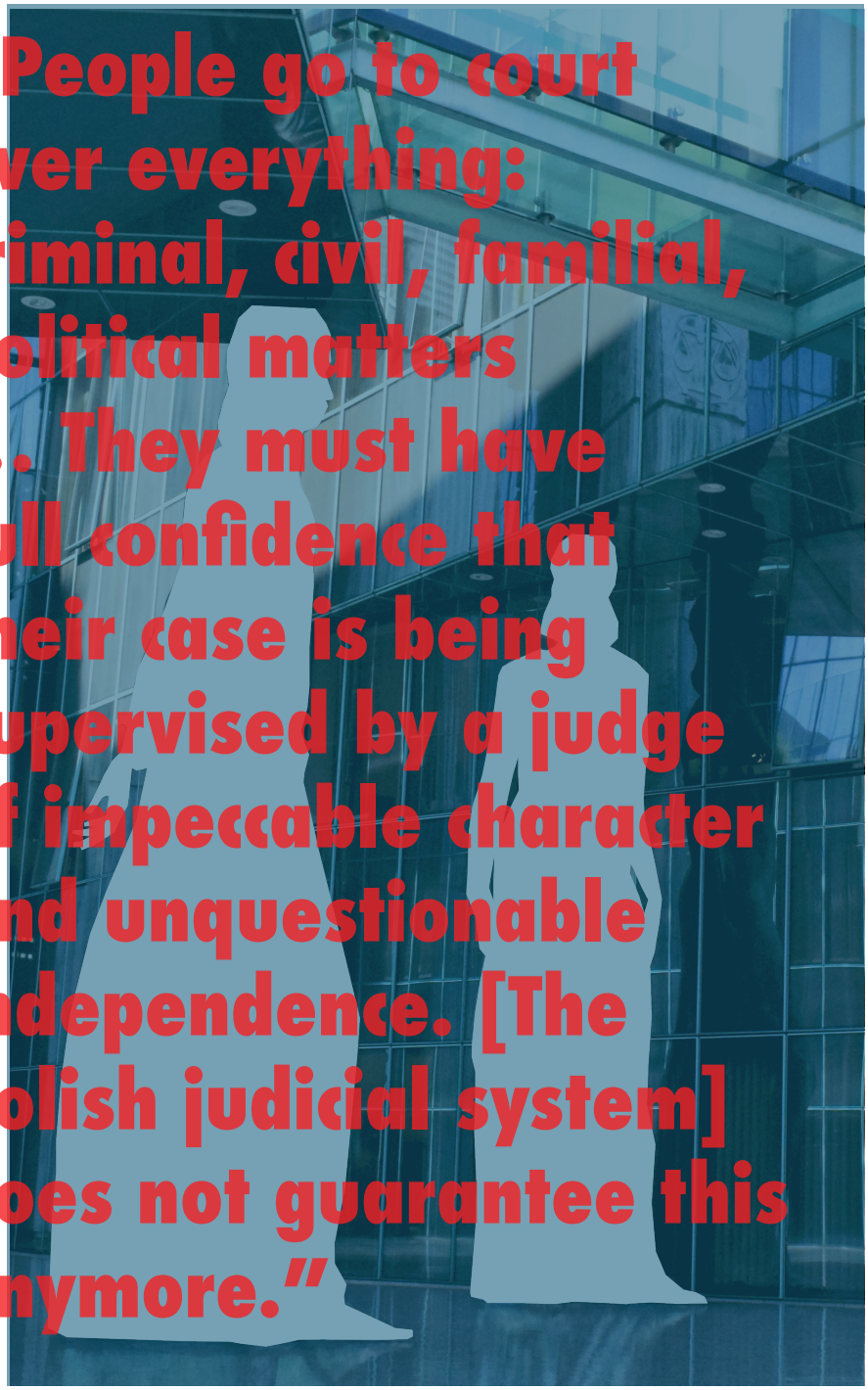
"People go to court over everything: criminal, civil, familial, political matters … They must have full confidence that their case is being supervised by a judge of impeccable character and unquestionable independence. [The Polish judicial system] does not guarantee this anymore," said Rzepliński.

Apart from newly appointed judges with clear political motives, there are many judges who remain immobilized by the ever-looming prospect of punishment, despite their attempts to act impartially.

According to Łętowska, Polish judges currently find themselves torn between two conflicting forces: the legal system established by the Polish Constitution, and the web of reforms enacted by the Polish government that "avoid, break, and bend" this same constitution. Judges seeking to exercise their independence must grapple with the threat of governmental pushback.

"Courts are organs that should protect, by their very nature, the realization of that which exists in its abstract form in the Constitution and in the law. If courts are nonfunctional for any reason at all, then of course that influences the situation of the citizenry," said Łętowska.

Łętowska noted that the majority of Polish courts are still doing their best to abide by the Polish Constitution. Howev-



er, courts respond to accusations filed by branches of state-run law enforcement, such as prosecutor offices and the police, which abide by the whims of the government. Given that Polish courts act in response to law enforcement allegations, "it is obvious that those who are disliked by the political regime will suffer," said Łętowska.

The Polish government's assault on judicial independence is, in the words of Kelemen, "a means to an end. And the end is to replace pluralistic democracy with a one-party electoral autocracy."

By stripping Polish citizens of their fundamental right to a fair trial, and by paving the way for a one-party regime which, Kelemen said, inevitably entails "restrictions on the free press and civil society organizations," the government's attacks on judicial independence endanger the freedom of the Polish citizenry.

As governmental repression deepens over all aspects of civic life in Poland, the prospect of recovering the independence of the country's judiciary branch, and the freedom of the citizenry at large, appears grim. However, hope remains.

Kelemen pointed to Poland's "vibrant civil society" as a principal source of hope. He noted that the country's "strong tradition of protest" and resistance to autocracy serves as a deterrent against the current regime's authoritarian ambitions.

Morijn agreed. "What I really admire, and that's why I put so much time in supporting judges in Poland, is that they're really fighting. It's really individuals who have a backbone of steel, who are putting everything on the line to defend what they were appointed for," he said.

Poland's membership in the EU is another source of hope. Morijn noted that being part of a broader system of European law, in which a country may seek assistance from other member states who share "the same community of values," will make it easier for Poland to protect its own judicial system.

Morijn also argued the next election result will be decisive for the fate of the Polish judiciary. If the democratic opposition comes to power, he said, it may put into motion a form of "transitional justice" to restore judicial independence.

In the words of Łętowska, "history teaches us that everything is possible after the fall of a regime." Łętowska also noted, however, that the recovery of judicial independence in Poland will be "an incredibly long process," and that although the next elections may bring about a change in the country's political leadership, such a change on its own will be insufficient.

The Polish government's assault on the judiciary is an assault on the democratic principles for which Polish civil society has fought across generations. Today, that fight lives on.

Łętowska and Rzepliński spoke to The Politic *in Polish; their remarks have been translated.*

A Thumb on the Scales

Democrats Boost Extreme Candidates in GOP Primaries

BY **OWEN HAYWOOD**



KELLY SCHULZ is every bit a classic conservative. To her, being a Republican is "about small government, it's about less taxes, it's about good education, it's about individual freedoms." Her words hearken back to an older Republican Party, one defined by traditional conservative values. Endorsed by her mentor, Maryland's popular outgoing Republican governor, Larry Hogan, Schulz seemed like the obvious choice to be his successor.

Schulz's main opponent in the Republican primary race, Dan Cox, represented the pro-Trump Republican faction. A disciple of the falsehood that Donald Trump won the 2020 election, Cox holds an often conspiratorial set of views that have come to define far-right politics over the past ten years. Schulz, unafraid to criticize these beliefs publicly, went into election night with full confidence in her ability to prevail.

But as one county after another tallied their counts, Schulz's chances changed from uncertain to fading, then to bleak. At 10:30 p.m. on Tuesday, July 19, Schulz stepped out on stage to deliver a few remarks. With her family behind her, she vowed to her crowd of supporters not to give up until the results were certain. By that Friday, they were. Schulz had lost the nomination to Trump-endorsed Cox.

Given that Trump's influence still looms large in the Republican Party, Cox's victory was not especially remarkable. However, one detail was unusual: the Democratic Governors Association had spent $1.7 million to help Cox win.

IT WASN'T JUST COX. Other right-wing beneficiaries of Democratic spending included Doug Mastriano in Pennsylvania's gubernatorial election; Darren Bailey for governor in Illinois; John Gibbs of Michigan's 3rd House district; and Donald Bolduc and Robert Burns for New Hampshire's Senate seat and 2nd House district, respectively. Each of these six candidates won their Republican primaries with the help of Democratic spending this year — not to mention seven additional conservative candidates who benefited from ads in the primaries but did not advance to the general election.

This midterm election cycle had huge stakes for both parties. Vulnerable Democratic majorities in both the House and Senate and ten contested governorships were on the ballot. If Republicans flipped either house of Congress, they could hobble the Democrats' domestic agenda. The results of governors' races could determine state-level action on issues ranging from gun control to abortion access.

With this in mind, Democrats employed a novel, hard-ball political strategy: running ads in favor of the most extreme, most Trump-loyal candidates. Organizations like the Democratic Governors Association (DGA) and Democratic Congressional Campaign Committee (DCCC) poured nearly $54 million into funding far-right candidates across the country. Spending on a candidate from another party is a counterintuitive idea that violates what seem to be the basic rules of partisan division, particularly when the resources are directed to the candidates who stand the furthest from your party ideologically. But the strategy follows a cold logic: a more extreme candidate has greater difficulty appealing to moderate and centrist voters and therefore is easier to defeat in a general election.

Tylir Fowler, a second-year Yale PhD student studying political science, recognizes the political logic of this approach. "In competitive electoral races, I can see that [strategy] as being pretty effective," said Fowler, who focuses on populism and the electoral influence of money and interest groups. He pointed out that academic research compellingly suggests that more extreme candidates fare poorly in general elections.

The entire strategy hinges on advertisements' influence on the opinions of the voting public. While research on the effectiveness of general election ads is mixed, Fowler said that "ads can definitely play a role" in primaries. He explained that primary candidates cannot rely on voters falling back on partisan identification when casting their vote, and instead have to focus on building their brands and name recognition.

During GOP primaries, Democratic advertisements sought both to portray Trump-backed candidates as more conservative than their opponents and boost their name recognition. Ads that linked

Organizations like the Democratic Governors Association (DGA) and Democratic Congressional Campaign Committee (DCCC) poured nearly $54 million into funding far-right candidates across the country.

Cox to Trump strengthened his standing with the Republican base, while potentially weakening his general election prospects, especially in a blue state like Maryland. Democratic spending elevating Cox, Schulz said, "helped increase the name recognition of one candidate over the others." Advertisements mean name recognition, and name recognition means primary success.

The Democrats used their money as a thumb on the scales, a way to tip the balance in these primaries to make sure the most extreme candidates won. In Maryland, Cox defeated Schulz by a margin of fewer than 26,000 votes. In this race, not just every vote counted, but every ad, too.

In all six races where Democrats intervened to elevate extreme Republican primary candidates, the Republican lost the general election.

SUPPORTING EXTREME primary candidates comes with an inherent risk: what happens if the far-right individual wins their election? "Elevating these candidates is just not a wise strategy," said Micah English, a first year Yale PhD student in Political Science studying race and ethnic politics. English pointed to examples of successful far-right candidates. "As we have seen, like with the election of Donald Trump and with the election of all these other anti-democratic candidates, people are still going to vote for them," she argued. In 2016, some Democrats celebrated when Donald Trump won the Republican primary under the assumption that his extreme style of conservatism would spell defeat in a general election. It didn't.

Beyond concerns over the risk of defeat, Democrats have expressed worry over the long-term strategic and moral implications of this spending. Kyle Mayer '22, a former president of the Yale Democrats, spoke to *The Politic* in his personal capacity. "I find it, in a few words, grossly irresponsible," Mayer said. "We are really at a democratic inflection point in this country." Mayer suggested that by bringing attention to extremist candidates, Democratic leaders are boosting anti-democratic ideals that undermine the very basis of the already-fragile US democracy. Mayer does not believe "the ends justify the means."

Alvaro Perpurly '22, who has worked or volunteered on over 30 Democratic campaigns, agreed that Democrats are giving right-wing extremists "a platform to speak up." All thirteen GOP candidates supported by Democrat-backed organizations in 2022 refused to acknowledge the results of the 2020 election, made baseless claims about the occurrence of fraud, or supported President Trump's actions leading up to the January 6, 2021 insurrection.

Mayer mused that the very act of "trying to manipulate" the internal processes of another party could itself undermine democracy. Similarly, Fowler said that by interfering with the outcomes of primary elections, the Democratic Party "might undermine the will" of those within the Republican Party, sabotaging the GOP's ability to democratically choose candidates.

Schulz questioned whether Democratic voters and donors are fully on board with their strategists' tactics. "If I were a Democrat, I don't know if I would feel really happy about it," she said. Schulz posited that it might be frustrating for some Democrats to have their hard-earned money spent on extreme candidates from the other party.

But to some Democrats, the high stakes might mean that an otherwise immoral strategy is now justified. Fowler, the political science PhD student, argued that from a Democrat's perspective, the moral dilemma of uplifting far-right candidates is "not negligible." However, "the benefits might outweigh the ethical concerns." Perpuly similarly expressed that he understands the logic of the strategy, especially considering in light of what he sees as even more unsavory attempts by the GOP to subvert election results. "With so much at stake, it's easy to see why they do this," he said. "It's my hope that we can get to a place where this does not have to happen."

Democrats who feel this tactic was justified can point to one piece of evidence in their favor: it worked. After Cox defeated Schulz in the Maryland gubernatorial primary, he went on to lose the governor's race to Democrat Wes Moore in November by nearly 30 percent. In fact, in all six races where Democrats intervened to elevate extreme Republican primary candidates, the Republican lost the general election. Nationally, voters in the 2022 election rebuked candidates with anti-abortion stances and patterns of election denialism – exactly the

kind of candidates that the Democrats elevated with this strategy. Forty-four percent of voters cited worries over the future over democracy as a primary concern in the midterm election, according to exit polls from the Associated Press. The Democrats' gambit to win more races paid off.

PUBLICLY, TOP DEMOCRATS have condemned the wing of the Republican Party that has undermined elections and refused to accept election results. Many have called for a reformed GOP. "I do believe that our democracy is in danger because of what the other side is saying about undermining our election," said Nancy Pelosi in an interview with CNN's Anderson Cooper on November 7, the day before the general election. "I do think a great deal of the healing has to come within the Republican Party itself. And it's not up to me to tell them how to shape themselves."

Do Democratic expenditures supporting extremist Republican candidates actively subvert this cause? A Democratic victory in Congress does not necessarily help stamp out anti-democratic ideology. To defeat extremism within the Republican Party, Democrats may need the help of moderate Republican candidates and voters alike, but the perceived hypocrisy of Democrats may undermine bipartisan efforts to create a healthier democratic culture. Peter Meijer, a Republican representative from Michigan's 3rd district who lost his primary to a far-right Republican supported by Democratic ads, publicly expressed anger with the Democrats over this funding. "I'm sick and tired of hearing the sanctimonious bullshit about the Democrats being the pro-democracy party," he said in an interview with *Politico*. Meijer is one of ten House Republicans who voted to impeach Trump following the January 6th insurrection.

The influence of an ideology cannot just be measured by the number of congressional seats held or the number of governor's mansions occupied. The Dan Coxes and the Doug Mastiranos of the political world do not have to hold office for their views to matter. Thousands of people still turned out to vote for candidates willing to deny election results and espouse social views far from those of the median voter.

In 2022, Democrats' interventions in GOP primaries helped them maximize their electoral success. However, it might be too early to evaluate the long-term consequences of turning up the volume on anti-democratic rhetoric in an already unstable political environment. There is no guarantee that the public will deem far-right extremists unelectable forever. Democrats must reckon with whether they are harming democracy in the name of saving it.

Democrats must reckon with whether they are harming democracy in the name of saving it.



FROM FARM

The Mississippi River Carries the Consequences

BY **GREY BATTLE**

POLLUTION POURING into the Gulf of Mexico has created a harrowing scene: rose-colored algae covers the seafloor, and decomposing wildlife blankets the shore. An ever-expanding "dead zone," where low dissolved oxygen kills or displaces undersea life, now occupies a record 6,334 square miles.

The crisis is fueled by fertilizer runoff from Midwestern farms washing down the Mississippi River. Excess nutrients found in fertilizer overload Gulf waters and promote the rapid growth of algae. When the algal bloom eventually settles to the bottom and begins to decompose, it depletes dissolved oxygen and causes the dead zone where oxygen levels are not high enough for fish to survive.

For those who live along and make their living off of the Gulf, the dead zone is devastating. "The Black Bay and Breton Sound areas and American Bay and California Bay used to be just an unbelievably productive oyster fishery back there," said Chris Nelson, a fourth-generation fisherman and current president of Bon Secour Fisheries, a large seafood purveyor in Louisiana. "It produces virtually no oysters anymore."

Pollution has overwhelmed the diverse marine ecosystem that once thrived on the Southern coast. "Where there's high nutrient Mississippi water spilling into the area, the oysters either don't reproduce, don't survive, or don't grow," said Nelson.

He wonders why regulators are not doing more to address the problem. "I have an [National Pollutant Discharge Elimination System] permit here to limit the pollution that I can create in my local surface water. Why is agribusiness upstream of the Mississippi River not required to limit nutrient loading?" Nelson asked. "Limiting nitrogen and phosphorus nutrients that cause the water of the Mississippi River to be harmful downstream, that can have an effect tomorrow."

In 2001, the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) and twelve Mississippi River basin states agreed to work together to reduce two-thirds of the dead zone by 2015, which would require a reduction in nitrogen runoff from the Midwestern Corn Belt by 45%.

That deadline has now been extended to 2035. Today, the zone is 2.8 times larger than the 2035 target set by the task force.

Don Scavia was a member of the Federal-State-Tribal task force that worked with the EPA to create the 2001 Action Plan. He noted that runoff into

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of Biofuel Policy Downstream

the Mississippi River has stayed constant for 30 years, revealing the failure of the 2001 plan and similar actions.

Scavia argued that efforts to clean up the Gulf have fallen short because controls on nutrient pollution from agriculture are weak. What is needed is stronger political will. "Many billions of dollars have been spent through the farm bill on conservation measures, but the nutrient load to the Gulf (and the Chesapeake and Lake Erie) have not been reduced much, if at all," he said.

Before his work with the EPA, Scavia led an integrated assessment during the Bill Clinton administration to analyze the causes and remedies for the Gulf dead zone, pointing to Midwestern corn production as the primary cause. Corn production has expanded over the past decade due to the increasing use of corn ethanol, or biofuel. Biofuel, fuels derived from plant materials rather than limited crude oil and natural gas supplies, have been touted by some as a "carbon neutral" replacement to gasoline or diesel. However, a growing number of scientists, researchers, and activists believe policymakers have overlooked serious environmental harms associated with biofuel production such as changes in land use and nutrient pollution.

Scavia expressed the difficulty of conveying such concerns to lawmakers in the face of large agricultural interests. "The consequences of an overload of nutrients in our waterways have negative economic implications for fisheries, recreation, tourism, housing prices," he said. However, these problems go unsolved because "agricultural and energy interests are so much more powerful."

Even in Mississippi River basin states, lawmakers have opposed mandating maximum pollution loads. At the same time, nitrogen pollution has increased despite subsidies and the expansion of Midwestern agriculture has buried any water quality gains from increasing fertilizer efficiency. Since the 2001 agreement, biofuel production has expanded fortyfold and agriculture now contributes 73.2% of the nitrogen runoff into the Gulf of Mexico.

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THE BIDEN ADMINISTRATION'S signature climate legislation, the Inflation Reduction Act (IRA), is expected to exacerbate the growth of the Gulf dead zone despite the benefits it may bring to the farming and biofuel industries. The legislation's energy provisions include $500 million in grants to develop biofuel infrastructure and a renewable diesel tax credit to incentivise the use of biofuel. These measures would cover the costs of installation or upgrades to fuel dispensers, storage tanks, and distribution systems, allowing biofuel corporations to maximize production.

Geoff Cooper, President and CEO of the Renewable Fuels Association (RFA), praised the IRA as a transformative policy victory for biofuel companies. “The Inflation Reduction Act is going to present really enormous opportunities for our industry and will really stimulate a new wave of investment and innovation in the ethanol industry,” he said.

Biden's policy will create new demand for corn and increase its value. “Farmers are now making a profit whereas, before the ethanol industry existed, they were just barely breaking even or were losing money,” said Cooper.

Cooper grew up on a farm and ranch in Central Wyoming. “I've been around agriculture all my life and I've always had a passion and interest in adding and creating value for agricultural products,” he explained.

His interest in energy security began during his time in the army. Cooper was deployed overseas in the Middle East and witnessed firsthand the dangers of foreign oil dependency. After his service, he worked for the National Corn Growers Association (NCGA) as Director of Ethanol Programs at the beginning of the biofuel boom (2003-2013). At both the RFA and NCGA, Cooper has advocated on behalf of the biofuel industry. While his initial message evolved from securing energy to decarbonization, Cooper's objective has stayed the same for nearly 20 years.

Cooper dubbed the last decade of biofuel growth the “Ethanol Era.” He argued that there have been a number of years during this decade that the size of the Gulf dead zone shrunk while biofuel production expanded, though recent reporting shows that the area steadily increased during this time. In addition, according to Cooper, some farmers have adopted more efficient practices like conservation tillage, covering a third or more of the soil surface with crop residue to reduce fertilizer runoff.

He explained that support for the energy provisions in the IRA relied on the environmental sustainability of biofuels. “Democrats in Congress were generally convinced that the tax provisions are in the best interest of the American public, and that they are absolutely going to be impactful in reducing carbon emissions and combating climate change,” Cooper said.

TWENTY YEARS AGO, John DeCicco also thought biofuels were the answer to renewable energy. His early research was based on the premise that biofuels would recycle carbon dioxide (CO_2). While some CO_2 is initially released through the burning of biofuel to power industrial production and transportation, he believed the CO_2 would eventually be pulled back out of the air once corn and soybeans were grown to produce more biofuel. Scientists call these plants the “feedstocks” of biofuel. They make up the closed cycle that justified early energy policy. DeCicco later found this cycle to be too simplistic.

After the passage of the Renewable Fuel Standard, one of the first American policies to expand biofuel production, DeCicco and fellow researchers took a closer look at the impacts of biofuels. They found that biofuel production creates a carbon debt, resulting from a change in land use from rainforests, peatlands and grasslands to corn farms. When the original plants and soil are cleared, the carbon they contained is released into the atmosphere. Researchers calculated that this process could release up to 420 times more carbon than it saves from replacing fossil fuels.

are oil spills due to to dead zones due uction in the Gulf of co?”

DeCicco described a long-standing division in the scientific community on the sustainability of biofuels. Certain researchers promote biofuels as a clean alternative to fossil fuels, while others consider biofuels to be comparable, if not worse, in terms of environmental harm. Much of the work on biofuels is done through computer modeling, which leaves a high degree of uncertainty. Depending on the assumptions that are made, modelers can find vastly different results from one and other.

DeCicco explains that many of the researchers in government-sponsored agencies often justify the carbon benefits of biofuels, just as he did during the early stages of his career. “They’ve been funded to analyze biofuels in support of a long-standing policy decision that biofuels are worth promoting,” he said. DeCicco explained that many of the initiatives to expand biofuel production in the early 2000s were based on older understandings. Such decisions have created institutional inertia in the scientific community to reaffirm the advantages of biofuel.

According to DeCicco, agricultural lobbyists have promoted the idea that biofuels are an environmentally-friendly alternative to oil and gas. However, DeCicco believes that the comparison between biofuel and fossil fuels is like comparing a rotten apple to a rotten orange. “How do you compare oil spills due to Deepwater Horizon to dead zones due to agricultural production in the Gulf of Mexico?” he asked.

While biofuel and corn corporations use sustainability as an argument to convince policymakers to back legislation like the IRA, many environmentalists disagree. “Corn ethanol is not a solution,” said Matt Rota, the Senior Policy Director for Healthy Gulf, an environmental advocacy group. “If you really look at it from cradle to grave, it doesn’t reduce greenhouse gases when you compare it to the burning of gasoline. It’s basically an incentive for agribusiness to grow, Monsanto to sell its corn seeds and its roundup.” Monsanto, now part of Bayer, is an agrochemical company that recently pleaded guilty to 30 different environmental crimes related to the pollution of corn fields.

Rota noted that the farm lobby has not only won subsidies and greater production incentives, but received exemptions from legislation regulating pollution. “Agricultural runoff is exempted from the Clean Water Act, the primary tool that we would use to reduce the pollution in water,” Rota said. “Farm lobbying organizations are very, very active in resisting any sort of regulation.” The result is that Gulf Coast communities and wildlife are “not taken into account when our policies are being made.”

Rota grew up in Southern Illinois, surrounded by cornfields. He explained that solutions exist to protect both the interests of farmers and the Gulf, and individual farmers are not the problem. Rota listed practices such as leaving buffers between streams and farmland, using precision agriculture, or planting cover crops that can protect surrounding water bodies from nutrient pollution. “[These] are not necessarily decisions that farmers can make if they are renting the

While those upriver may have more political capital, the Mississippi carries the consequences of misguided environmental policy downstream, where residents of Gulf Coast states pay the price.

land," he said. "A lot of these lands are owned by large agricultural firms and it's about maximizing yield and productivity as opposed to making sure that the land is well taken care of and [protecting] fisheries."

As nutrient runoff increases, the destruction of marine habitats along the coastline will continue to worsen. "Shrimpers are losing money and cannot afford to feed their families," said Roishetta Ozane, the Environmental Justice organizer at the Power Coalition for Equity and Justice, a New Orleans-based advocacy group. "What happens in the Gulf affects all of us: our fish, our shrimp, our oysters. A lot of the folks here, their livelihood is based on fishing."

Ozane is from Southwest Louisiana and began her work in environmental justice through social media. "I would just post on Facebook: Who needs help? How can I help you today? How can I pray for you?" she said. "And people would inbox me and I would help them the best I could."

She explained that while pollution itself does not discriminate, divisions become clear in the ability to recover from pollution. "For years and years, low-income communities have experienced a legacy of health disparities because of the disproportionate burden of pollution," she said. "Political infrastructure not only causes damage to our wildlife fisheries in our environment, but also to our health and safety hazards in Black, Brown, and Indigenous communities."

Both Ozane and fisherman Chris Nelson agree that legislators must keep people living along the Gulf Coast in mind. While those upriver may have more political capital, the Mississippi carries the consequences of misguided environmental policy downstream, where residents of Gulf Coast states pay the price.

"[Policymakers] need to look further upstream and think about what's causing the dead zone, where that water is going, and what it's doing to the coast," said Nelson. "I don't see anyone really doing much about it… that's one of the things that disturbs me about science in today's world: it seems to be driven by a lot of politics."

over-sub-scribed

Yale's Residential Colleges Struggle with Record Class Sizes

BY **SAMANTHA MOON AND REBECCA WASSERMAN**

THIS YEAR, Eliza Lord '24 is a junior in Davenport College. For the first time since she started at Yale, Lord will spend the entire academic year living within Davenport's walls. Her suite, a well-lit configuration of four singles and one double in Davenport's G entryway, is situated on the northern end of the college.

This arrangement is a far cry from Lord's accommodations last year. During the 2020-21 school year, she, along with the sophomores in Branford, Davenport, Morse, and Saybrook, lived on Old Campus—the large quad typically occupied by Yale's first-year students. Lord and her roommate shared a dark, cramped double in Vanderbilt Hall. Without a central dining hall or gym, Lord felt that Old Campus lacked the sense of community inherent to the residential colleges. She described it as a "no-man's-land."

Having never lived inside Davenport as an underclassman, Lord is not all that familiar with students in other classes. "I don't know anyone the year above or the year below me in Davenport," she said. "I think part of the purpose of living in the college your sophomore year is to know the people a year above you. So now I don't have that experience at all."

The result, Lord continued, is that she does not "feel connected at all to the greater Davenport community."

Students' sense of disconnection from their residential colleges is increasingly common. Together, ballooning undergraduate enrollment and fixed housing capacity have contributed to a current 1,357 students living off campus, according to Yale College Dean of Student Affairs Melanie Boyd. This number includes a record 35% of the junior class. Many of them have never been housed by their college—with the exception of the abbreviated fall 2020 semester during the pandemic.

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"FOURTEEN COLLEGES. One Yale." Those words headline the section of the Yale website devoted to explaining the residential colleges that sit "at the heart of the Yale experience." The website describes "a built-in, tight-knit family for students from the moment they arrive, blending diversity, camaraderie, and pride for one's residential community." Yale advertises the residential college system as an integral element of the undergraduate experience—a part of the DNA of Yale.

Yet the residential colleges could never reasonably house the entire undergraduate population. Yale expects that some share of juniors and seniors will be drawn off campus each year by the prospect of increased independence, meal flexibility, and a guaranteed single each year. But for upperclassmen who would prefer to live on campus, each time Yale's enrollment swells, so does housing uncertainty.

COVID-19 has only exacerbated these issues. Pandemic-related gap years and deferrals led to about 335 students postponing their matriculation from fall 2020 to fall 2021. Despite this significant roll-over, Jeremiah Quinlan, Dean of Undergraduate Admissions & Financial Aid, told *The Politic* in an email that University leaders "decided that the admissions office would not reduce the number of admissions offers to students who applied to enroll in fall 2021 and 2022." Over email, Boyd explained that Yale "made it a principle not to reduce the number of students admitted during COVID because we did not want to disadvantage applicants to the classes of 2024, 2025, and 2026." The class of 2025 is now a record size of 1,789. When asked if Yale Admissions considered the implications of expanding enrollment without expanding already-strained housing options, Quinlan said, "I am grateful that we have been able to offer admission to the same number of students graduating from high school each year, and I am proud that Yale has not reduced the number of high-achieving students from all backgrounds who are receiving a Yale College education." He did not address the impact of housing shortages on students already enrolled in Yale College.

IN 1961, the construction of Morse College and Ezra Stiles College represented Yale's first major expansion to housing since the founding of its residential college system in 1933. Morse and Stiles were built to alleviate tremendous housing burdens. A 1958 *Yale Daily News* (YDN) article quoted then-University President A. Whitney Griswold saying that a $15 million gift from Paul Mellon would allow Yale to relieve "the serious handicap of overcrowding caused by the 46% increase in our total undergraduate body since the war, and to expand and strengthen the college-centered educational activities that now play a major role in the educational life of the University."

In 1990, students in Davenport, Silliman, and Trumbull found themselves squeezed into quads originally designed to be doubles, or annexed out of their residential colleges all together. Mary Helen Goldsmith, then-Silliman Head of College, told the YDN in 1990 that "17 [Silliman] students voluntarily moved off campus when they heard housing would be tight." The same YDN article also reported that, "many students have signed leases for off-campus housing already, fearing that they might be forced out of their residential college with not enough time to procure desirable housing." According to another YDN article from the same year, Trumbull sophomores faced a severe crisis, with only 55 on-campus beds available for a class of 106. The situation is similar to the struggle that students in the class of 2024 faced during the spring 2022 housing draw.

Due to the untenable size of the class of 2025, many members of the class of 2024 have found that there is no space for them in their residential colleges. During the 2021-2022 school year, "I think there were 126 or so sophomores in Berkeley and like 220 [total] beds," said Matthew McNierney '24 in an interview with *The Politic*. "So [the class of 2025] was occupying more than half of the college." He explained that the large sophomore class caused an oversubscription of about 35 students in junior housing. According to McNierney, Berkeley College was allotted 18 beds for annex housing in Old Campus's McClellan Hall. If 17 students hadn't elected to move off campus, they would have effectively been kicked out. Similarly, in the housing draw for the 2022-23 academic year, Davenport was originally oversubscribed by 16 beds. After six left the draw, the remaining ten juniors were annexed to an entryway in Pierson College.

WHEN ASKED TO COMMENT on housing shortages and community preservation in their residential colleges, the Deans and Heads of College of all 14 residential colleges declined.

"The residential colleges, even for students not living in them, are important communities for all undergraduates,"

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Boyd wrote to *The Politic*. She continued, "I'm pleased that we have reached a point in the pandemic where in-person events like college teas, IMs, and Mellon fora have been reinstated, and they are open to all students, whether they live on campus or off."

Much as the residential colleges may make a valiant effort to involve the entire community in events, students contend that a certain level of community is only attained through physically living in their college. In his current room in McClellan Hall, McNierney is acutely aware of the separation from residential college life. Unlike Berkeley College, McClellan Hall has no suites. Rather, McNierney's floor consists of standalone singles that open directly onto a long hallway. McNierney laments the loss of the common room as a social space. "It's definitely a little bit more difficult to just see the people that I live next door to because their door is closed," McNierney said. Despite loving his college community, McNierney shared that he "definitely [has] way less interaction with Berkeley College" due to its distance from McClellan.

Unlike McNierney, Alexa May Richards '24 has spent all three years living in Pauli Murray, her residential college. Richards eagerly described her connections to the community. She said, "I feel like I'm constantly running into people in the college, running into Prof. T [Murray's Head of College] . . . And I think that those just sort of happenstance things may or may not happen to someone who lives off campus." Richards explained that many of her friends are in Murray, and she frequents events hosted there by her Head of College. "I do think it is one of the core pieces of my college experience," she said.

Students like Richards who have lived in their college every year are more easily able to integrate themselves into their college communities. These students' experiences are in line with the effects of proximity on relationship building that many psychologists have identified. When students are involuntarily isolated from their residential colleges, Yale's selling point of a "built-in community" begins to fall apart.

In spring 2021, Branford College planned to add beds to rooms, turning some singles into doubles and doubles into triples. Given that Branford was not allotted annex housing, this move was necessary to accommodate the large influx of new students expected in the fall. Mark Deng '23, a current Branford senior, moved off campus his junior year to avoid these cramped rooms. "I think residential colleges are great for the first two years, when you're trying to establish yourself at Yale and need a community that's readily available to you," Deng told *The Politic*. "However, as time goes on, you have friend groups established all over the campus, and that's when the physical space of residential colleges doesn't matter that much anymore."

Richards agreed with Deng's assessment. "I think people get into the residential college thing to varying degrees," he said. "And if you're not super attached to it, then, like, it's not that hard to move away."

EACH SPRING, Yale upperclassmen wait in anticipation to learn if they have secured a spot in their residential college. Some make plans to move off campus months in advance, preferring to avoid the uncertainty of the housing draw and the disadvantages of late entry into the rental market. The students who move off campus voluntarily and those who are forced off by oversubscription both live a degree removed from their greater residential college community. They are distanced from lazy afternoons in the grassy courtyards, late nights in the butteries, and other defining characteristics of residential college life.

While COVID-related developments are in part responsible for Yale's present space shortages, the pandemic is not the first time Yale has struggled with college housing. The University's difficulties addressing campus housing shortages over the past 70 years suggest that the issue is structural.

To ensure that residential college life is at the "heart" of the undergraduate experience, as Yale promises, the University has a couple options. If the student population remains at its current size, and especially if it continues to grow, the University could prioritize an expansion of its housing options—though this construction must address the effect an expansion would have on New Haven residents, who are already under stress as more students move off campus and drive up rents. Otherwise, enrollment numbers must shrink to reflect the current capacity of the school's residential colleges. As it stands, Yale has not been able to house all its students.

On the Front Line

An Interview with CNN's Clarissa Ward on Ukraine



BY **KATE REYNOLDS AND LEONIE WISOWATY**

Clarissa Ward is an award-winning British-American conflict journalist, and is the current chief international correspondent for CNN. After graduating from Yale College in 2002, she has spent the last two decades reporting from the front lines of Syria, Iraq, Afghanistan, Ukraine, and Georgia. In 2020, Ward ivestigated the poisoning of Alexei Navalny and interviewed him in an undisclosed location. Last year, she reported from Kabul, Afghanistan during the first few days when the Taliban took control of the city. Recently, Ward has been covering the ongoing Russian invasion.



YOU WERE IN KHARKIV, UKRAINE DURING THE INITIAL INVASION—CAN YOU PAINT US A PICTURE OF WHAT THE FIRST DAYS AND WEEKS OF THE INVASION WERE LIKE?

I had been in Ukraine since mid-January. I didn't think the invasion was going to happen—I was lobbying to go home again because I have two young kids. Then Putin gave this very ominous speech where it became clear that despite the predictions of many people who had spent a lot of time in Russia and knew Russia quite well, this invasion was going to happen.

Once we knew that, we had to try to work out where we thought the invasion would occur. At that stage, there were very few people entertaining the idea that it could be a full blown national invasion in Kyiv and across the country. So we decided to go to Kharkiv, which is Ukraine's second largest city and directly across the border from Russia. As we were driving there, we got a phone call from our bosses saying that they were hearing off the record that the war was going to start that night.

We got to our hotel, and it was pitch black. It was very eerie. Eventually, it was 4 A.M., and it seemed like nothing was happening. I happened to look on Twitter before getting into bed, and I saw that Putin was speaking. We all rushed back up to the roof, and you could hear the explosions rippling across the night sky as missiles began slamming into Ukraine. We were live for several hours, and then slept for a few hours. The next morning, we began trying to get a feel for what was going on.

In those initial days, people were in a state of shock. Ukrainians had also been led to believe by their leaders that this was not going to happen—that there wasn't going to be an actual invasion. So they were in deep shock. We went to the subway station where people were hunkered down. They didn't have food or bathrooms. They were just waiting and hoping that there would be some kind of guidance as to what they should do or where they should go. What was extraordinary to see, though, was just how quickly the Ukrainians adapted to the war. Despite not being fully prepared for this moment, in a matter of days they were mentally and physically ready for a big fight. Whether that was soldiers or old ladies building Molotov cocktails in their garage and getting ready to throw them at the Russians as they came in, it was pretty remarkable.

RECENTLY, YOU REPORTED FROM THE REGAINED TERRITORIES IN UKRAINE, AND YOU DESCRIBED IT AS A "GRIM VICTORY." THESE AREAS ARE NOW UNDER UKRAINIAN CONTROL AGAIN, BUT THEY'RE IRREVERSIBLY DAMAGED BY THE WAR.

That story was about a series of villages and towns and Kherson Oblast that had been liberated. As is often the case with victory in such an ugly conflict, it comes at a huge price. Once you get past the initial jubilation, there's a lot of darkness, trauma, and destruction. In a country that is still at war, it can be hard to find resources for the governing authorities to use to repair some of that damage. These towns or villages were pretty much destroyed in the heavy fighting—almost every single house had some kind of damage, if it wasn't altogether obliterated. They had no electricity, no running water, and very little contact with the outside world to try to get aid or help with their rebuilding.

There are these Ukrainian police units that go around to investigate damage and some to investigate sexual assault. All of them have different purviews, looking at different war crimes. They have a huge task in front of them. It can be hard because [Ukrainians] feel ashamed. People don't know the names of the Russians involved in this. They don't remember the unit. There's many reasons for why it's an uphill climb for these investigators, but they continue to do it because it is really important work. Recently, I interviewed this elderly woman whose house had been destroyed. Her son had been injured fighting on the front lines and was in a rehabilitation facility. She was desperately afraid that she was completely alone. You leave someone like that and you think, Gosh, how is this person going to eat? Where is she going to sleep? The Ukrainian state has such an enormous task in trying to care for its citizens and trying to protect them—not just those who are living under current fire, but also those in liberated areas that have been decimated.

PUTIN HAS EXPRESSED INTERST IN EXPANSION BEFORE—HE BRIEFLY INVADED GEORGIA IN 2008 AND ANNEXED CRIMEA IN 2014. I KNOW THAT YOU WERE STATIONED IN GEORGIA DURING THE 2008 WAR. I'M CURIOUS IF YOU SEE PARALLELS BETWEEN YOUR EXPERIENCE IN GEORGIA AND UKRAINE, OR WHAT THE PREVIOUS INVASIONS SAY ABOUT THE CURRENT INVASION?

It shows that Putin has been softening up the ground for a long time in terms of getting ready for a moment like this and preparing the international community for the possibility of an invasion. It also shows, though, that he has radically overshot the mark and does not understand the reality of the competence of his own military, the desires of his own people, or the willingness of NATO allies to come together in full union to fight this and defend Ukraine. He grossly underestimated how hard it was going to be and how much resistance he was going to face, internally and externally. In Crimea, the Little Green Men—as [the Russian soldiers] were called—arrived in town and people put up their white flags. The whole thing was done in a matter of days. That was the expectation for this, which tells you that Putin is getting really bad advice from people in his inner circle and that decades of rampant corruption will hollow out any institution, whether it's your military or judiciary.

If you think of it as poker, he can bluff his way through multiple rounds and win with a pair of twos and everyone's like, how does he do that? That's because he knows how to play a hand. In this case, he has grossly misread the situation and has now been forced to capitulate.

THERE'S SUCH A LACK OF ACCESS TO RUSSIA AND THE SENTIMENT OF RUSSIANS. GIVEN TAHT YOU SPENT SOME TIME LIVING IN RUSSIA AND HAVE CONTACTS AND FRIENDS IN RUSSIA, HOW ARE THEY DESCRIBING THE SITUATION THERE?

The main thing I would say is that Russia is not a monolith. There are different perspectives depending on who you talk to. Some people in Russia are exceptionally wealthy and powerful, but not directly involved with the government. Those people are irritated by the war because they've lost a lot of money. They've lost a lot of power. They've lost their ability to go to Saint Tropez on their yacht in the summer, and that annoys them. They're also resentful towards the West because they feel that Putin was boxed into a corner and that that is why this invasion happened.

Then you talk to other people, like the middle-class Russians, who are educated and have traveled but don't have that kind of wealth. Many of them feel deeply ashamed and heartbroken about the war in Ukraine and don't know what to say or even what their future is in their own country. They understand that everything they've worked for three decades is now destroyed and won't be rebuilt for another generation, realistically. So there's a lot of heartache.

You also have a lot of ordinary Russian people who don't have money, haven't traveled, and aren't well-educated. Their only information is state-sanctioned propaganda. I would say that they are pro-war in the sense that the war has been framed as a kind of continuation of Russia's resistance to Nazis during WWII. The war is being framed as a defense against NATO and the West trying to kill Russia. But these people are still not lining up to send their sons to volunteer to fight in Ukraine. This is what I think President Putin has found challenging, as we saw with the partial mobilization. That was hugely unpopular. If he has to do something like that again, it remains to be seen whether he would be able to pull that off, particularly as thousands and thousands of Russian soldiers continue to come back in body bags.

RECENTLY, YOU INTERVIEWED A UKRAINIAN WOMAN NAMED TATIANA WHO WAS ALLEGEDLY RAPED BY A RUSSIAN SOLDIER. WHAT STRUCK ME ABOUT THAT VIDEO WAS THAT TATIANA'S FACE WAS HIDDEN TO PROTECT HER IDENTITY, BUT THE VIEWERS COULD WATCH YOUR REACTION. YOU HAD SUCH A HUMAN, EMOTIONAL RESPONSE, WHICH WAS REALLY MOVING. COULD YOU DESCRIBE HOW YOU MANAGE BEING IN SUCH INTIMATE SETTINGS AND CONVERSATIONS WITH THESE PEOPLE? THEN, YOU EVENTUALLY GO BACK TO "NORMAL LIFE." YOU ARE ABLE TO LEAVE CONFLICT. WHAT IS THAT LIKE?

What we did was sort of by accident. We had two cameras and one of them was on me, and I was incredibly emotional because I was watching her break down in front of me and talk about this shame she was carrying. I had a really human reaction to that. That ended up helping us tell Tatiana's story in a way that the viewer could latch on to and connect to.

I think traditionally in journalism, there has been a resistance to cross that line a little bit.

Part of the reason you see that space being explored a lot more these days is because so many more women are doing this kind of reporting. As a woman, I don't really have a problem bringing emotion into the story if it belongs there. I don't have a problem focusing on humanity. Traditionally, that was seen as too sentimental. The news was thought of as giving the facts—what happened, where it happened, the guns being used, the tactics. That gives people a lot of knowledge, which is really important. I'm not saying those things aren't important, but my goal with this kind of storytelling is to allow viewers to feel connected to these people and feel that they have a glimpse into what these people have been experiencing.

Now, the downside of that is that it does mean that when I do these interviews, I am very open to other people's pain and trauma. You're very present for them when they're telling their story because it's a big moment for a lot of people, especially rape victims. Talking about that kind of trauma is extremely difficult. You would be naive to think that just because you leave the war zone and go home and have your "real life" again, that you don't carry some of that with you—consciously or on your body. There are many different ways that we hold on to trauma, even if it's not our own trauma. The best way that I have found to mitigate that, to the extent that it can be mitigated, is to be proactive and aware about self care.

For me, it's become a lot easier since I've had kids. Before I had kids, I would come home and feel really detached from my life. You can't really feel that kind of numbness with your children. It's this geyser of love that is always there. That really helps me feel my way back into real life.

If you're going a million miles per hour, and you're working so hard, not sleeping, driving endlessly, trying to make your deadlines, in incredibly stressful and often dangerous situations—it means you're running on a lot of adrenaline. When that adrenaline goes away and you return to a more predictable place, you're going to crash. It's the laws of physics. It's going to happen. You're not going to avoid the crash, but you can at least put down a nice mattress to try to cushion it and just try to be good to yourself once you get home.

This interview has been condensed and edited for length and clarity.

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